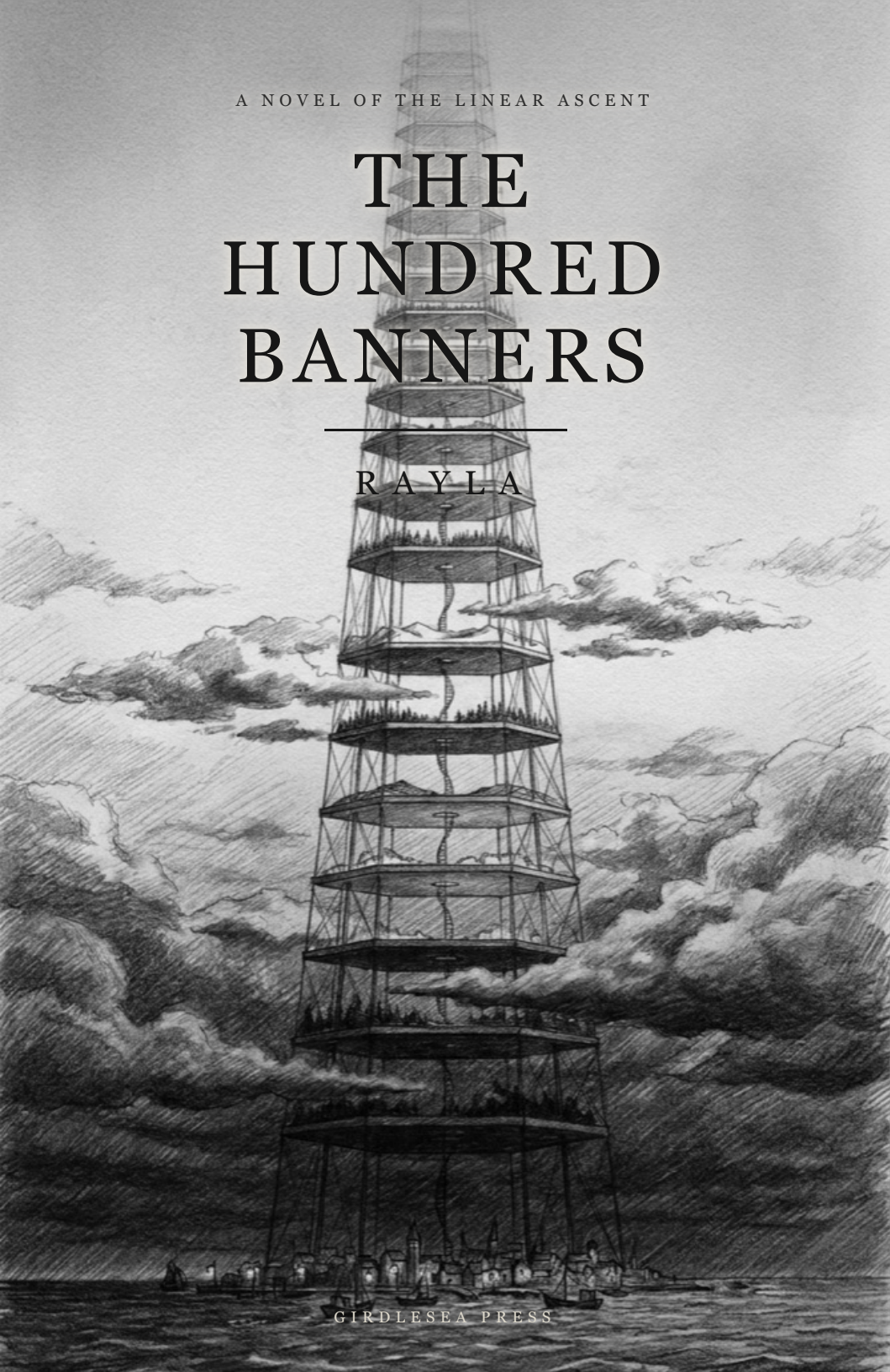




A NOVEL OF THE LINEAR ASCENT

THE HUNDRED BANNERS

RAYLA

GIRDLESEA PRESS

The world did not end. It was *taken* — cut country from country and stacked a hundred floors high, each stolen land a cell in the sky, so that its peoples could never again gather against the thief who keeps the throne at the top.

Eighty years later, a trainer of raw recruits buries her last debt at the foot of the tower and starts to climb. What begins as one woman's reckoning becomes a rising the tower was built to make impossible: a hundred banners, a hundred freed floors, an army that grows by the very thing it frees. With an elf archer who does not miss and a giant mender who will not kill, Ede Harrow must bargain with spider-queens and storm-courts, out-mourn a dead king, and learn the one truth the tower hides: the Wardens do not hold the tower up. They hold the light out.

"A megastructure epic with a farmer's heart. The best first sight of a tower since fantasy learned to look up."

— The Lanternmoth Review

"Rayla writes war the way keepers keep gates: patiently, by name, and then all at once."

— Harrowport Courant

"The ladder turns gold and you will cry. We do not make exceptions and we did not expect to make one here."

— The Girdle-Sea Almanac